

FREE RESOURCE

Elementary Counselor's Conversation Starters

Age-appropriate prompts for K–5 — what to say, and what never to say

 Grief & Loss

 Anger & Frustration

 Anxiety & Worry

 Friendship Conflict

 Divorce & Family Changes

 New Student

 Bullying

 Suspected Abuse / Neglect



GRIEF & LOSS

- K-2** "Can you draw me a picture of your favorite memory with [person]?"
- K-2** "Sometimes our hearts feel heavy. Can you show me where yours hurts?"
- 3-5** "What's the hardest part of your day right now?"
- 3-5** "If you could tell [person] one thing right now, what would it be?"
- All** "It's okay to feel sad and happy in the same day. Both feelings are real."



ANGER & FRUSTRATION

- K-2** "Your body looks like it has big feelings right now. Can you show me what color your anger is?"
- K-2** "Let's take 5 dragon breaths together. Ready? Breathe in through your nose... out like a dragon."
- 3-5** "On a scale of 1–10, how angry are you right now? What would it take to bring it down by 2?"
- 3-5** "I notice you're upset. Tell me what happened from the very beginning."
- All** "Being angry is okay. What we DO with anger is the part we get to choose."



ANXIETY & WORRY

- K-2** "If your worry was a monster, what would it look like? Let's draw it and make it smaller."
- K-2** "Let's play the 5-4-3-2-1 game. Tell me 5 things you can see right now."
- 3-5** "What's the worst thing you think could happen? Now... what's the most LIKELY thing?"
- 3-5** "If your best friend had this same worry, what would you tell them?"
- All** "Your brain is trying to protect you. Let's teach it that you're safe right now."



FRIENDSHIP CONFLICT

- K-2** "Can you tell me what happened using 'I felt ___ when ___'?"
- K-2** "If this was a story, what would the happy ending look like?"
- 3-5** "What do you think [friend] was feeling when that happened?"
- 3-5** "What part of this is yours to fix, and what part is theirs?"
- All** "Being a good friend doesn't mean never disagreeing. It means caring even when you disagree."



DIVORCE & FAMILY CHANGES

- K-2** "Your family is changing, but your people still love you. Who are your safe people?"
- K-2** "Some things change and some things stay the same. Let's make a list of what stays the same."
- 3-5** "This is NOT your fault. I need you to hear that. None of this is because of anything you did."
- 3-5** "What questions do you have that nobody has answered yet?"
- All** "You don't have to choose sides. You're allowed to love everyone."



BULLYING

- K-2** "Thank you for telling me. That was really brave. You are not in trouble."
- K-2** "Nobody gets to make you feel small. Let's talk about what happened."
- 3-5** "How long has this been happening? You don't have to handle this alone anymore."
- 3-5** "I believe you. And we're going to make a plan together so this stops."
- All** "Telling someone is not tattling. Telling someone is being brave."



NEW STUDENT / TRANSITION

- K-2** "I'm so glad you're here! Can you tell me one thing you're really good at?"
- K-2** "Being new is hard. Who's been nice to you so far? Let's build your friend list."
- 3-5** "What do you miss about your old school? What are you hoping for here?"
- 3-5** "I'm your person here. Whenever you need help, you come find me. Deal?"
- All** "Every single person in this school was new once. You belong here already."



SUSPECTED ABUSE / NEGLECT

- All** "I'm really glad you told me. You did the right thing."
- All** "This is NOT your fault. I need you to know that."
- All** "My job is to keep you safe. I'm going to help."
- All** "I can't promise to keep this a secret, because I care about your safety too much."

⚠️ DO NOT ask leading questions. DO NOT promise confidentiality. DO document the student's exact words. DO report within 24 hours to DFPS (Texas Abuse Hotline 1-800-252-5400) or a law enforcement agency — many districts require both, and your district's own police department does not count (Texas Family Code §261.101, as amended by SB 571, 2025). Reporting is your personal duty and cannot be delegated.

WHAT NOT TO SAY — Common Mistakes

Replace harmful defaults with healing responses

✗ Don't Say	Why It Hurts	✓ Say Instead
"You're okay."	Dismisses their feelings. They clearly are NOT okay.	"I can see this is really hard. I'm here."
"Just ignore them."	Tells them their pain doesn't matter and removes your responsibility.	"That sounds hurtful. Let's talk about what happened."
"Why did you do that?"	Triggers defensiveness. "Why" puts them on trial.	"Help me understand what happened."
"I know how you feel."	You don't. And it centers you instead of them.	"I can't imagine how hard this is. Tell me more."
"Everything happens for a reason."	Minimizes grief. There is no good reason a child lost someone.	"This is so unfair. I'm sorry this happened."
"You need to be strong."	Teaches them to suppress emotions. Suppressed emotions come back as behavior.	"It's okay to not be okay right now."
"Boys don't cry." / "Big girls don't cry."	Gendered emotional suppression. Harmful at every age.	"Crying means you care. That's a strength."
"I'm disappointed in you."	Shame — the #1 predictor of repeated behavior.	"I know you can do better than this. What happened?"
"Wait until your parents hear about this."	Weaponizes family. Creates fear, not growth.	"Let's figure out how to fix this. Then we'll talk to your family together."
"You should be grateful."	Dismisses their experience by comparing it to others.	"Your feelings matter, no matter what."
"That's not a big deal."	It IS a big deal to them. Minimizing = dismissing.	"I can see this matters a lot to you."
"Just try harder."	If they could, they would. Something is blocking them.	"What's getting in the way? Let's figure it out together."
"I'm too busy right now."	Tells them they're not a priority. They won't come back.	"I want to hear this. Can we meet in 10 minutes? I'll come find you."
"Don't tell anyone."	NEVER. Especially with safety concerns.	"I'm glad you told me. Some things I need to share to keep you safe."
"At least..."	Any sentence starting with "at least" minimizes.	Just listen. Sometimes silence and presence is enough.